AEP FROM ZERO • PART 3 • PROVE WHAT WORKED (CJA)

EPISODE 29

Marketing Attribution Models Explained (CJA)

Marketing attribution models explained from zero in Customer Journey Analytics (CJA): what a touch, a lookback window and a container are, and how first touch, last touch, linear, U shaped, J curve, time decay and algorithmic attribution split the same revenue. Using Adobe's 50-dollar example and Bloom's customer Priya, you build a CJA attribution panel, read the swing between models to find openers and closers, and see why attributed revenue is smaller than total revenue. You also learn the three places

Previously: Gold is worth more per order

- Last time: segments explain, audiences act
- One revenue-per-order metric for everyone
- Gold $78, Silver $55, Bronze $38 per order
- Today: two teams claim the same revenue
- Rohan referees with attribution models

KEY IDEA

Last time, one shared metric showed Gold spends 78 dollars per order. Today two teams claim the same revenue, and Rohan referees with attribution models.

Two teams, one pot of money

- Relaunch fortnight: 1,240 orders, $66,260
- Paid search team: our ads brought them in
- Email team: our emails made them buy
- Both claims together: more than Bloom earned
- Bonuses and next quarter's budget depend on it
- Anjali: I need a referee, not a cheerleader

KEY IDEA

Paid search and email each report the same orders as their own. Added together, their claims come to more than Bloom earned, and Anjali needs a referee.

Touch, lookback window and container

Word	Meaning
Touch	One contact, such as an email click
Lookback window	How far back a touch can earn credit
Lookback choices	Reporting window, 14/30/60/90, Custom
Container	Person: all visits. Session: one visit
Session container	Forces lookback to the reporting window

Customer Journey Analytics, as of 2026

KEY IDEA

A touch is one contact with a channel. The lookback window is how far back a touch can still earn credit. The container decides whose touches count together.

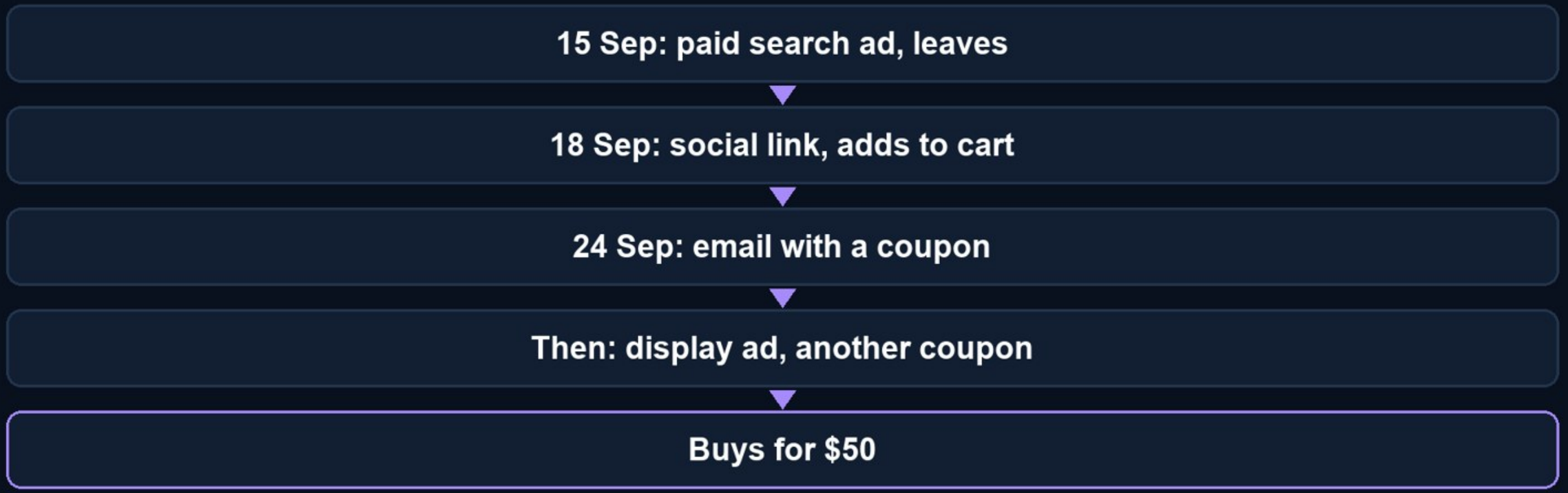
Attribution is an assumption you choose

- Every model is a rule for sharing credit
- None is true; each answers a different question
- Change the model: same money, new story
- A referee announces the rules before the match
- Name the model and the window every time

KEY IDEA

No model is the truth. Each tells a different story about which touch deserves credit, so you choose one for a question and name it every time.

First touch, last touch and linear



KEY IDEA

Adobe's example: paid search, social, an email coupon and a display ad lead to one 50-dollar order. First touch, last touch and linear tell three different stories.

U Shaped, J Curve, Inverse J, Time Decay

Model	Adobe's $50 example, in dollars
U Shaped (40/40/20)	Search 20, social 5, email 5, display 20
J Curve (60 to last)	Display 30, search 10, social 5, email 5
Inverse J (60 to first)	Search 30, display 10, social 5, email 5
Time Decay (7-day half-life)	Most to the two touches on purchase day
First touch, Session container	Email 50: only the last visit counts

Person container, 30-day lookback unless stated

KEY IDEA

U Shaped, J Curve and Inverse J give fixed shares to the first and last touch. Time Decay favours touches close to the order. The container can flip it all.

Eleven models: which one should you use?

Question you are asking	Models that fit
What brought people in?	First Touch, Inverse J
What closed the sale?	Last Touch, J Curve
Did every channel help?	Linear, U Shaped, Participation
Does recency matter?	Time Decay (half-life 7 days)
Statistical or your own?	Algorithmic, or Custom weights

Models as listed in Customer Journey Analytics, 2026

KEY IDEA

CJA offers eleven models, and Last Touch is typically the default. Let the question choose the model, compare several, and name the one you used.

Priya's two touches, and why stitching matters

Model	Paid search	Email
First touch	$54	$0
Last touch	$0	$54
Linear	$27	$27

Illustrative channels only; Person container

KEY IDEA

Say Priya first came from a paid search ad on her phone, then an email on her laptop, and paid 54 dollars. Only stitching lets any model see both touches.

Building the attribution panel



KEY IDEA

Insert, Attribution opens a panel with five inputs: Success metric, Channel, Included models, Container and Lookback window. Then you click Build.

Read the swing, not the rank

What you see	What it means
Bigger under First Touch	An opener: it brings people in
Bigger under Last Touch	A closer: it finishes the sale
Barely moves between models	Steady: credit holds under any model
A big swing	The fight is about this channel

KEY IDEA

Do not crown the tallest bar. Watch how each channel moves between models: one that gains under first touch opens sales; one that gains under last touch closes them.

Attributed total, total revenue and overlap

- Panel total: all revenue in the panel's dates
- Attributed columns: only orders with a touch
- The gap: a tracking gap, like No value
- Table vs panel: default model vs your model
- Channel overlap: Venn of the top three channels

KEY IDEA

Orders with no channel touch inside the window earn no credit, so the attributed total is smaller than total revenue. The Channel overlap Venn shows shared conversions.

Three places to set a model

Where	How (as of 2026)	Who it affects
One metric column	Column settings, non-default	Only that column
Calculated metric	Gear on the metric	Everyone using that metric
Data view default	Set attribution on metric	Every report, everyone

Labels as of October 2026

KEY IDEA

A model can be set on one column, inside a calculated metric, or as the data-view default. Only the default changes every report, for everyone.

Ranges, not one triumphant number

- 1. Where the money moves: a range per channel
- 2. The rules: models, container, window, dates
- 3. The test that would settle it: a holdout
- Attributed revenue is not incremental revenue
- Confidence stated honestly, with its limits

KEY IDEA

Anjali gets a range for each channel, the named model and window, and a test that would confirm it. Attributed revenue is not incremental revenue.

Interview corner

- Models are assumptions, not truths
- Name the model and the window every time
- Which model is best? The question decides
- Compare three models and read the swing
- Attributed is not incremental: confirm with a holdout

KEY IDEA

Attribution models are assumptions, not truths. Name the model and the window every time.

Recap, your question, and the next leak

- Touch, lookback window, container: name them
- Read the swing: openers versus closers
- Attributed total is smaller than total revenue
- Column, calculated metric, or data-view default
- Next: fallout, flow and cohort analysis

KEY IDEA

Models are rules you choose; read the swing; set models in the right place. Next: fallout, flow and cohorts, and where Bloom really loses customers.